

In fine form: Merab Dvalishvili has secured victories over former champions Petr Yan, Henry Cejudo, and UFC Hall of Famer Jose Aldo in three of his last five fights. GETTYIMAGES

'THE MACHINE' REVVING UP FOR O'MALLEY CHALLENGE

Merab Dvalishvili, nicknamed **'The Machine'**, is eagerly awaiting a potential showdown with O'Malley.

Nigamanth P
nigamanth.p@thehindu.co.in

In recent weeks, the pressing question among UFC enthusiasts and analysts has revolved around Merab Dvalishvili's next bout. His remarkable 10-fight winning streak, placing him third among active bantamweight contenders, has stirred considerable interest.

Following Sean O'Malley's successful defence of the bantamweight championship at UFC 299 against Marlon Vera, speculation suggests that Dvalishvili is next in line for a title shot. As he currently occupies the top spot in the bantamweight rankings, 'The Machine' eagerly anticipates a potential showdown with O'Malley.

"Since I'm top ranked, I will be fighting for the belt next. O'Malley

wants September, and I'm up for it. I'm training as hard as I can," said Merab in an exclusive interaction with Sportstar.

Merab debuted in professional MMA in 2014 before joining the UFC in 2017. Despite a strong pre-UFC record, his early UFC career stumbled with two consecutive losses, including a submission defeat to Ricky Simon of the USA. "I lost my debut fight because I was sick, but the second was an outright loss. It was tough. But I learned a lot from these two fights. I kept my head down and continued to train hard. That helped me find my rhythm and guided me to where I am today," Merab said. Merab has secured victories over former champions Petr Yan, Henry Cejudo, and UFC Hall of Famer Jose Aldo in three of his last five fights. Out of the 10 wins, Merab

has managed to finish just one opponent: Marlon Morales via submission back in 2021. When deciding to go aggressive or play the waiting game, 'The Machine' believes that the nature of his opponents is the decisive factor.

"There are two things to take into consideration. First, my opponents are tough, and it's hard to finish them. Second, in my initial two fights, I was rushing my opponents, trying to finish them, and because of those two mistakes, I lost. So, I'd rather win by dominating my opponents for three rounds than make any mistake," Merab said.

But when Merab faces O'Malley, he wants to knock him out. "Everybody thinks I cannot strike. I'm a complete mixed martial artist, and I want to show the world that I can knock him out Mexican style," he concluded.

Sony Sports Network is the official broadcaster for the UFC in India.